Kennedy needed time to think things through. He told the CIA's deputy director, Marshall S. Carter, that he wanted information about the missiles to be put "back in the box and nailed tight." Carter obliged, buying Kennedy some extra time. The president asked Secretary of State Dean Rusk to start working on a public statement. Scarred by his meeting with Khrushchev in Vienna and making no progress with the Soviet leader on nuclear test-ban negotiations or Berlin, Kennedy was coming to distrust Khrushchev as a negotiating partner and had little hope of solving the growing problem in Cuba by appealing to him through diplomatic channels. The only appeal that made sense to him was a public one. It would tell Khrushchev that there were limits to what he could accept regarding the Soviet presence in Cuba.[5]

Later that day Kennedy flew to Rhode Island to spend the long weekend with Jackie, Caroline, and John Jr. He also visited Hyannis Port to see his paralyzed father, Joseph. But the Cuban missiles stayed on his mind. On Saturday, September 1, the first full day of the long weekend, in a telephone conversation with General Carter, Kennedy eased the ban on information about Cuba. Access to it would now be extended to a select group of officials "on a need to know basis for the purpose of preparing a comprehensive hearing for the President Tuesday morning."[6]

Cuba was becoming an absolute priority for Kennedy's foreign policy team, overshadowing its previous object of obsessive concern—West Berlin. The threat of military confrontation was moving dangerously close to the American mainland. But few of those around the president believed that Cuba was simply replacing Berlin in Soviet strategy. For a while it seemed that the Berlin crisis was the bigger and more threatening one. Kennedy and his advisers would judge anything pertaining to Cuba first and foremost with reference to the situation in Berlin.

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WITH HIS HARVARD PEDIGREE AND CONNECTIONS, KENNEDY was able to assemble the most intellectually impressive foreign policy team ever seen in Washington. It included the forty-one-year-old former dean of arts and